

Storage Carrots

CULTIVARS

- Bolero

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 6 rows (5" - 12 cm) per bed spaced every 2" (5 cm) on the row
- Size 1.8-2.0: JANG 3X seeder: X-24, 11F-13B, brush "0", ≠

FERTILIZATION

- Alfalfa meal (2-0-2) or chicken manure (5-3-2) in bed where the previous crop was amended with compost

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per beds) or sprinkler.

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Medium (24"-40")
- Need deep watering until later stages of root development, at which time excess water can cause roots to crack. Cracking is also caused by too great a fluctuation between wet and dry.

IMPLANTATION

Storage carrots typically follow garlic in our crop rotation. The storage carrots benefit from the maturation of the compost added in autumn (before the garlic). The goal is to harvest them after one or two big frosts—they become much sweeter!

EQUIPMENT

- Broadfork
- Rotary harrow
- Jang seeder 3X + X-24 rollers, scale, notepad and your seeds
- 30" rake
- Flame-weeder

ITINERARY

- pre-emergent flame weeding (when beds are available 7 to 10 days before the seeding date)
- Pass through with the broadfork.
- Remove large debris from the bed if needed (use flail mower, rake or manually remove the large chunks).
- Uniformly apply the alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 1" (2.5 cm).
- Rake one last time, removing small rocks and debris. The bed must be completely clean.
- Cover the beds with floating row cover to promote the growth of weeds.
- Install sprinklers and keep beds well moistened at all time.
- 7 days later, seed using the Jang 3X. Check seeding density by measuring the weight of seeds distributed.
- Place a handful of beet seeds (as an indicator) at the end of one of the beds and identify with a flag. The beets are the control plants which will indicate when to flame weed (under the same conditions, beets always germinate before the carrots). Set an alarm or reminder to yourself to check daily, after the 8th day, to see if the beets have emerged. For the seeding to be successful, it is crucial not to miss this indicator.

- As soon as the indicator seeds germinate, flame weed the beds. Adjust the flame weeder to full throttle and move forward slowly and evenly. Your carrots will now have an important head start on any weeds.

WEEDING

- If flame weeded or seeded onto compost, weeds generally won't compete with your crop. We nevertheless cultivated our beds once to keep them really clean.
- 20-25 days after direct seeding when the carrots are at least 3-4" (8-10 cm) use bio-disc to cultivate on the row and between the rows in one single pass. Hand pull the biggest weeds.
- After that point, we don't spend time weeding any further. Weeds that emerge after that point shouldn't compete with the crop or have time to go to seed before the carrots are harvested, and are therefore a low priority.

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PLANT PROTECTION

- No action is required

HARVEST

The harvest of storage carrots is always a big job, given that we aim to have carrots for sale throughout the fall and winter. Whole plots can be harvested at once, so we plan to have the maximum number of people on hand to complete the task.

To speed up the harvest, we use a cutting blade that is mounted behind an old Ford tractor (the tractor wheels fit perfectly with the spacing of our beds). The bar is passed through the soil at a depth of 9" (22 cm). Be sure to set the blade at the correct angle to lift the carrots, and check the depth frequently to ensure that you're not damaging them. The bins are lined up with plastic bags that fit nicely the container. The plastic helps with storage longevity.

- One or two people pull the carrots, lining them besides each other, while others sort (keeping only the carrots in good condition), remove their tops and finally place them in a storage bin.
- Damaged or abnormal carrots are left in the fields or sorted into another bin for juicing carrots.

- 1 person should harvest 250 to 300 lbs of carrots per hour depending on their quality in the field.

CONDITIONING

- Carrots are washed as they are sold. The storage bins arriving from the fields are therefore placed on pallets in the fridge. Rinse the bins beforehand to remove all traces of dirt. Identify the bins.
- Until they are sold, they are stored in the storage bins with the dirt. They keep much longer if stored unwashed.
- At the time of sale, wash carrots in the root washer until they are really clean. Hose the carrots before entering the washer, so any dirt on the carrots is soft.
- Bag and sell according to orders.

STORING

- Storage carrots are stored in cold room kept at 35 °F (2 °C).